PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English

CHAPTER 1

A Letter to God

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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A Letter to God · Activity

1 **One of the cheapest ways to send money is through the post office. Discuss the meanings of these words: counter, counter clerk, appropriate, acknowledgement, counterfoil, record. Are there words corresponding to these English words in your languages?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **counter:** the long table/window in a post office or bank where customers are served.
- **counter clerk:** the employee who serves customers at the counter.
- **appropriate:** suitable or correct for the purpose.
- **acknowledgement:** a written receipt saying that something (money/letter) has been received.
- **counterfoil:** the part of a form or cheque kept by the sender as a record.
- **record:** written information kept for future use or proof.

In Hindi: counter – काउंटर/खिड़की, clerk – लिपिक, appropriate – उचित, acknowledgement – पावती, counterfoil – प्रतिपर्ण, record – अभिलेख.

2 **Fill out the Money Order form using the clues. What would you write in the 'Space for**

Communication'?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Fill in: amount in words and figures, receiver's name and address with PIN, date and sender's signature; in the Acknowledgement part, the sender's own name and address with PIN.

Space for Communication (sample): "Dear Ravi, I am sending ₹200 for your birthday. Buy a good book. With love, Amit."

2 (i) **In addition to the sender, the form has to be signed by the _____.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

the **receiver (payee)** – and also by the postal officials (postmaster/paying official).

2 (ii) **The 'Acknowledgement' section of the form is sent back by the post office to the _____ after the _____ signs it.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

sent back to the **sender** after the **receiver (payee)** signs it.

2 (iii) **The 'Space for Communication' section is used for _____.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

writing a **short message** from the sender to the receiver.

2 (iv) **The form has six sections. The sender needs to fill out _____ sections and the receiver _____.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

The sender fills out **three** sections (the money order part, the sender's name and address in the Acknowledgement, and the Space for Communication); the receiver only **signs** – in **two** places (Signature of Payee in the official part and in the Acknowledgement).

(Check with the form in your book.)

⭐ A Letter to God · Oral Comprehension Check (1)

1 **What did Lencho hope for?**

✔ **ANSWER**

Lencho hoped for **rain** – a downpour or at least a shower – because his field of ripe corn needed water for a good harvest.

2 **Why did Lencho say the raindrops were like 'new coins'?**

✔ **ANSWER**

Rain would give him a good harvest and so bring money. So he called the big drops “ten cent pieces” and the little ones “fives”.

3 **How did the rain change? What happened to Lencho’s fields?**

✔ ANSWER

A strong wind began to blow and very large **hailstones** fell with the rain for an hour. The field became white “as if covered with salt”; the corn was totally destroyed and the flowers were gone.

4 **What were Lencho’s feelings when the hail stopped?**

✔ ANSWER

His soul was filled with **sadness**. He felt the hail had left nothing – worse than a plague of locusts – and that his family would go hungry that year.

⭐ A Letter to God · Oral Comprehension Check (2)

1 **Who or what did Lencho have faith in? What did he do?**

✔ ANSWER

He had firm faith in **God**, whose eyes "see everything". He wrote a letter to God asking for a hundred pesos, wrote 'To God' on the envelope and posted it.

2 **Who read the letter?**

✔ ANSWER

A postman first saw it and showed it to his boss; then the **postmaster** opened and read it.

3 **What did the postmaster do then?**

✔ ANSWER

To keep Lencho's faith in God alive, he collected money from his employees, gave part of his own salary and took help from friends. He sent a little more than half (seventy pesos) in an envelope signed 'God'.

⭐ A Letter to God · Oral Comprehension Check (3)

1 **Was Lencho surprised to find a letter for him with money in it?**

✔ ANSWER

No. He showed **not the slightest surprise**, because he was fully confident that God would help him.

2 **What made him angry?**

✔ ANSWER

He got angry when he counted the money and found only **seventy pesos** instead of a hundred. He believed God could not make a mistake, so he thought the post office employees had stolen the rest.

🤔 A Letter to God · Thinking about the Text

1 **Who does Lencho have complete faith in? Which sentences in the story tell you this?**

✔ ANSWER

Lencho has complete faith in **God**. Sentences that show this:

- "But in the hearts of all who lived in that solitary house... there was a single hope: help from God."
- "All through the night, Lencho thought only of his one hope: the help of God, whose eyes... see everything, even what is deep in one's conscience."
- "Lencho showed not the slightest surprise on seeing the money; such was his confidence."
- "God could not have made a mistake, nor could he have denied Lencho what he had requested."

2 **Why does the postmaster send money to Lencho? Why does he sign the letter 'God'?**

✔ ANSWER

He sends money so as **not to shake the writer's faith in God**; he admired such faith ("I wish I had the faith of the man..."). He signs it 'God' so that Lencho believes God himself has answered and his faith stays strong.

3 **Did Lencho try to find out who had sent the money to him? Why/Why not?**

✔ ANSWER

No. He was sure the money had come from **God**, so there was no question of finding out who sent it. His faith was complete and unquestioning.

4 **Who does Lencho think has taken the rest of the money? What is the irony in the situation?**

✔ ANSWER

Lencho thinks the **post office employees** took the rest; he calls them "a bunch of crooks".

Irony: the very people who collected the money from their own pockets to help him and to save his faith are called thieves. Their kindness is repaid with suspicion – the opposite of what one expects.

5 **Are there people like Lencho in the real world? What kind of a person would you say he is? (greedy, naive, stupid, ungrateful, selfish, comical, unquestioning)**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, there are simple people like Lencho who have deep, blind faith in God. Lencho is:

- **naive** and **unquestioning** – he believes God will send money by post and never doubts it;
- **ungrateful** – he does not thank anyone and calls the kind post office staff crooks (without knowing the truth).

He is a hard-working farmer ("an ox of a man"), simple and honest, not greedy – he asks only for what he needs.

6 **There are two kinds of conflict in the story: between humans and nature, and between humans themselves. How are these conflicts illustrated?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Humans vs nature:** Lencho, a hard-working farmer, waits for rain; it comes, but turns into a hailstorm that destroys his whole crop. He is helpless before nature and his family faces hunger.

- **Humans vs humans:** Lencho and the post office employees. The postmaster and staff help him with money, but Lencho, getting only seventy pesos, distrusts them and calls them “a bunch of crooks”. This conflict comes from his blind faith and lack of understanding.

🤔 A Letter to God · Thinking about Language

I **Match the names (gale, whirlwind, cyclone, hurricane, tornado, typhoon) with their descriptions and fill in the blanks.**

✔ ANSWER

1. A violent tropical storm in which strong winds move in a circle: **cyclone**
2. An extremely strong wind: **gale**
3. A violent tropical storm with very strong winds: **typhoon**
4. A violent storm whose centre is a funnel-shaped cloud: **tornado**
5. A violent storm with very strong winds, especially in the western Atlantic Ocean: **hurricane**
6. A very strong wind that moves very fast in a spinning movement and causes a lot of damage: **whirlwind**

II **Match the sentences in Column A with the meanings of ‘hope’ in Column B.**

✔ ANSWER

1. “I hope so.” – **wanting something to happen (and thinking it quite possible)**
2. “I hope you don’t mind my saying this...” – **showing concern that what you say should not offend or disturb the other person: a way of being polite**
3. “...new hope to HIV/AIDS sufferers.” – **a feeling that something good will probably happen**
4. “hoping against hope...” – **wishing for something to happen, although this is very unlikely**
5. “...in the hope of speaking to her...” – **thinking that this would happen (it may or may not have happened)**
6. “...everybody had given up hope...” – **stopped believing that this good thing would happen**

III **Join the sentences using who, whom, whose, which, as suggested.**

✔ ANSWER

1. I often go to Mumbai, which is the commercial capital of India.
2. My mother, who cooks very well, is going to host a TV show on cooking.

3. These sportspersons, whose performance has been excellent, are going to meet the President.

4. Lencho prayed to God, whose eyes see into our minds.

5. This man, whom I trusted, cheated me.

IV **Find sentences in the story with negative words, which express the following ideas emphatically.**

✔ ANSWER

1. The trees lost all their leaves: "**Not a leaf remained on the trees.**"

2. The letter was addressed to God himself: "**It was nothing less than a letter to God.**"

3. The postman saw this address for the first time in his career: "**Never in his career as a postman had he known that address.**"

V **Find metaphors from the story to complete the table and say what qualities are being compared.**

✔ ANSWER

Object	Metaphor	Quality or Feature Compared
Cloud	Huge mountains of clouds	The mass or 'hugeness' of mountains

Raindrops	New coins	Value – rain would bring a good crop and money
Hailstones	Frozen pearls	Shape, shine and white colour of pearls
Locusts	A plague of locusts	An epidemic that spreads very rapidly and leaves many people dead (total destruction)
Lencho	An ox of a man	Strength and hard work of an ox

⭐ A Letter to God · Speaking

1 **Have you ever been in great difficulty, and felt that only a miracle could help you? How was your problem solved? Speak about this in class.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample: Last year, the night before my board practical exam, I lost my file and felt only a miracle could save me. I was very worried. Next morning my classmate came and returned it – I had left it in her bag. My teacher said, "Stay calm and keep trying; help often comes from people around us."

Points: the difficulty → your feelings → how it was solved (people, effort, luck) → what you learnt.

⭐ A Letter to God · Listening

1 **Listen to the letter read out by your teacher and fill in the table.**

✔ ANSWER

Item	Answer
The writer apologises because	she hasn't written for a very long time
The writer has sent this to the reader	a birthday card
The writer sent it in the month of	September 2005
The reason for not writing earlier	they have just moved house (to a new home)
Sarah goes to	'Little Feet' school (very close to their new home)
Who is writing to whom?	Jaya is writing to Arti
Where and when were they last together?	At Bangalore, last year

⭐ A Letter to God · Writing

1 **Lencho suffered first due to drought and then by floods. Design a poster for your area on how to save water during summer and when it is available in excess.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

SAVE WATER, SAVE LIFE!

In summer:

- Close taps tightly; repair leaking pipes.
- Use a bucket, not a shower or hose, for bathing and washing vehicles.
- Water plants in the evening; reuse RO and kitchen water for plants.

When water is in excess (rainy season):

- Do rainwater harvesting – collect roof water in tanks.
- Make recharge pits and keep ponds and wells clean.
- Plant trees to stop soil erosion and floods.

"Every drop counts – catch the rain where it falls!"

Issued by: Eco Club, Govt. Sr. Sec. School (your area)

🤔 Dust of Snow · Thinking about the Poem

1 **What is a "dust of snow"? What does the poet say has changed his mood? How has the poet's mood changed?**

✔ ANSWER

A "dust of snow" means **fine particles of snow**. A crow shook them down on the poet from a hemlock tree. This small event changed his mood from **sad and regretful to happy**; it saved the rest of a day that he had "rued".

2 (i) **What are the birds that are usually named in poems? Do you think a crow is often mentioned in poems? What images come to your mind when you think of a crow?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Poems usually name beautiful birds like the nightingale, cuckoo, peacock, skylark or swan. A crow is rarely mentioned. A crow brings images of a black, harsh-voiced bird, often seen as a sign of bad luck, gloom or death.

2 (ii) **What is "a hemlock tree"? Why doesn't the poet write about a more 'beautiful' tree such as a maple, or an oak, or a pine?**

✔ ANSWER

A hemlock is a **poisonous** plant (tree) with small white flowers. The poet chooses it, not a beautiful tree, to show that even ordinary or unpleasant things in nature can bring joy and change our mood.

2 (iii) **What do the 'crow' and 'hemlock' represent — joy or sorrow? What does the dust of snow that the crow shakes off a hemlock tree stand for?**

✔ ANSWER

The crow and the hemlock represent **sorrow** (gloom, bad luck). The dust of snow stands for **joy, hope and a fresh start** – a small, happy moment that lifts the poet's spirits. So nature, even through gloomy things, can heal us.

3 **Have there been times when you felt depressed or hopeless? Have you experienced a similar moment that changed your mood that day?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample: Yes. Once I scored low marks in a test and felt very sad. On my way home a little child smiled and waved at me, and a cool breeze was blowing. That small moment cheered me up and I decided to work harder.

🤔 Fire and Ice · Thinking about the Poem

1 **There are many ideas about how the world will 'end'. Do you think the world will end some day? Have you ever thought what would happen if the sun got so hot that it 'burst', or grew colder and colder?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample: Yes, I think the world may end some day. Some believe it will end in fire, some in ice. If the sun got too hot and burst, the earth would burn up; if it grew colder and colder, the earth would freeze and no life could survive. Either way life would end.

2 **For Frost, what do 'fire' and 'ice' stand for? (greed, avarice, cruelty, lust, conflict, fury, intolerance, rigidity, insensitivity, coldness, indifference, hatred)**

✔ ANSWER

- **Fire** stands for **desire** – greed, avarice, lust, conflict, fury, cruelty.
- **Ice** stands for **hatred** – intolerance, rigidity, insensitivity, coldness, indifference.

Both these human feelings are strong enough to destroy the world.

3 **What is the rhyme scheme of the poem? How does it help in bringing out the contrasting ideas in the poem?**

✔ ANSWER

Rhyme scheme: **abaabcbcb** (fire, ice, desire, fire, twice, hate, ice, great, suffice).

The rhymes link the contrasting words: ‘fire’ is tied to ‘desire’ and ‘ice’ to ‘twice’ and ‘suffice’. The short lines and shifting rhymes keep bringing the two opposite ideas – fire (desire) and ice (hate) – side by side, showing that both are equally destructive.

🎉 **Chapter 1 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**